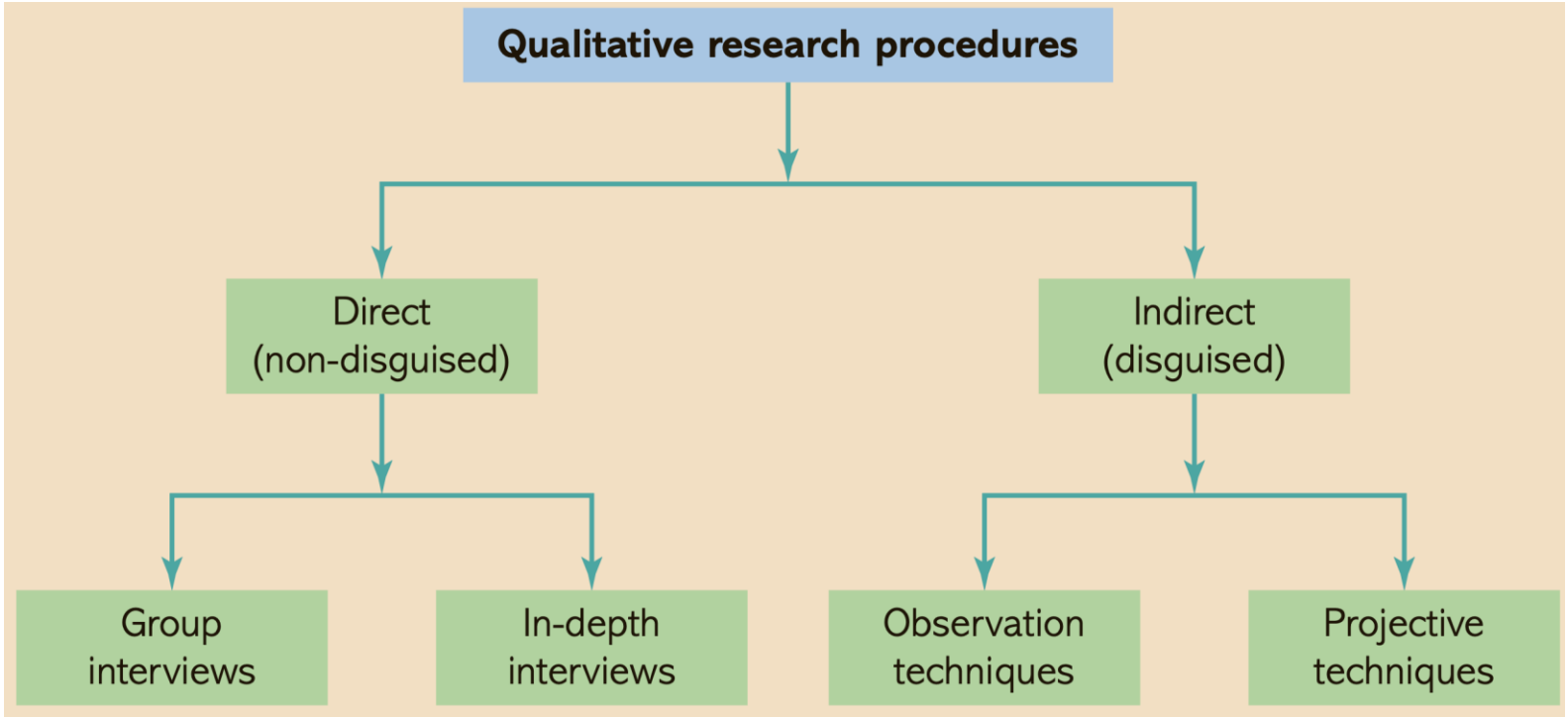
Focus Groups

Block 4

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Qualitative Research Techniques



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Qualitative Research Techniques

Direct Approach

- A type of qualitative research in which the purposes of the project are disclosed to the participant or are obvious given the nature of the interview.

Indirect Approach

- A type of qualitative research in which the purposes of the project are disguised from the participants.

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A Balancing Act

Ethical

- The right of the subject to know what a study is about
- Would partipicants feel cheated or abused by not being told the purpose

Data Richness

- How to get the best information possible from a subject
- How to get them in a creative mindset

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The Focus Group

- A focus group is a discussion conducted by a trained moderator among a small group of participants in an unstructured and natural manner.

- Used extensively in new product development, advertising development and image studies.

- The most popular of qualitative techniques

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Value of the Focus Group

- Most compelling purpose of the focus group is to bridge social and cultural differences between researchers and their target participants.
- The value of the technique and its role in bridging social and cultural differences lie in discovering unexpected findings, often obtained from a free-flowing discussion that is respectful and not condescending to participants

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The Moderator

- The moderator is an individual who conducts a focus group interview, by setting the purpose of the interview, questioning, probing and handling the process of discussion.

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Focus Group Characteristics

Characteristic	Description
Key Benefit	Group members 'feed' off each other and creatively reveal ideas which the researcher may not have thought of or dared to tackle
Key Drawback	Group members may feel intimidated or shy and may not reveal anything of significance
Group size	6–10
Group composition	Homogeneous, participants pre-screened by questionnaire or through known characteristics
Physical setting	Relaxed, informal atmosphere, 'comfortable' from the perspective of the participants
Stimulating discussion	Use of storyboards, mood boards, products, advertisements, films, music, websites, brochures
Time duration	1.5 to 6 hours (usually 1.5 to 2 hours)
Recording	Use of audiocassettes, videotapes and notes from observations
Moderator	Observational, interpersonal and communication skills

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Advantages of Focus Groups

Advantage	Description
Synergy	A group will produce a wider range of info, insight and ideas than an individual
Snowballing	A comment from one might create a chain reaction
Stimulation	People talk more when the group gets more involved in the topic
Security	Having other people who have similar thought makes you more secure
Spontaneity	Answers are not required therefore the answers given are voluntary
Serendipity	New ideas that the moderator never thought of come up
Specialization	Since multiple subjects are involved, the cost of the moderator is justified
Scientific scrutiny	The recording of session allows many researchers to validate and interpret collected data
Structure	Allows for flexibility of topics, logic , language and expression
Speed	Multiple individuals are interviewed at the same time

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Focus Group Disadvantages

Misjudgment	Results can be misjudged
Moderation	quality of the results depends upon how well the discussion is managed and, ultimately, on the skills of the moderator.
Messiness	The unstructured nature of the responses makes coding, analysis and interpretation difficult
Misrepresentation	Hard to generalize finding to a wider sample
Meeting	Hard to coordinate a time where all can individuals can get together

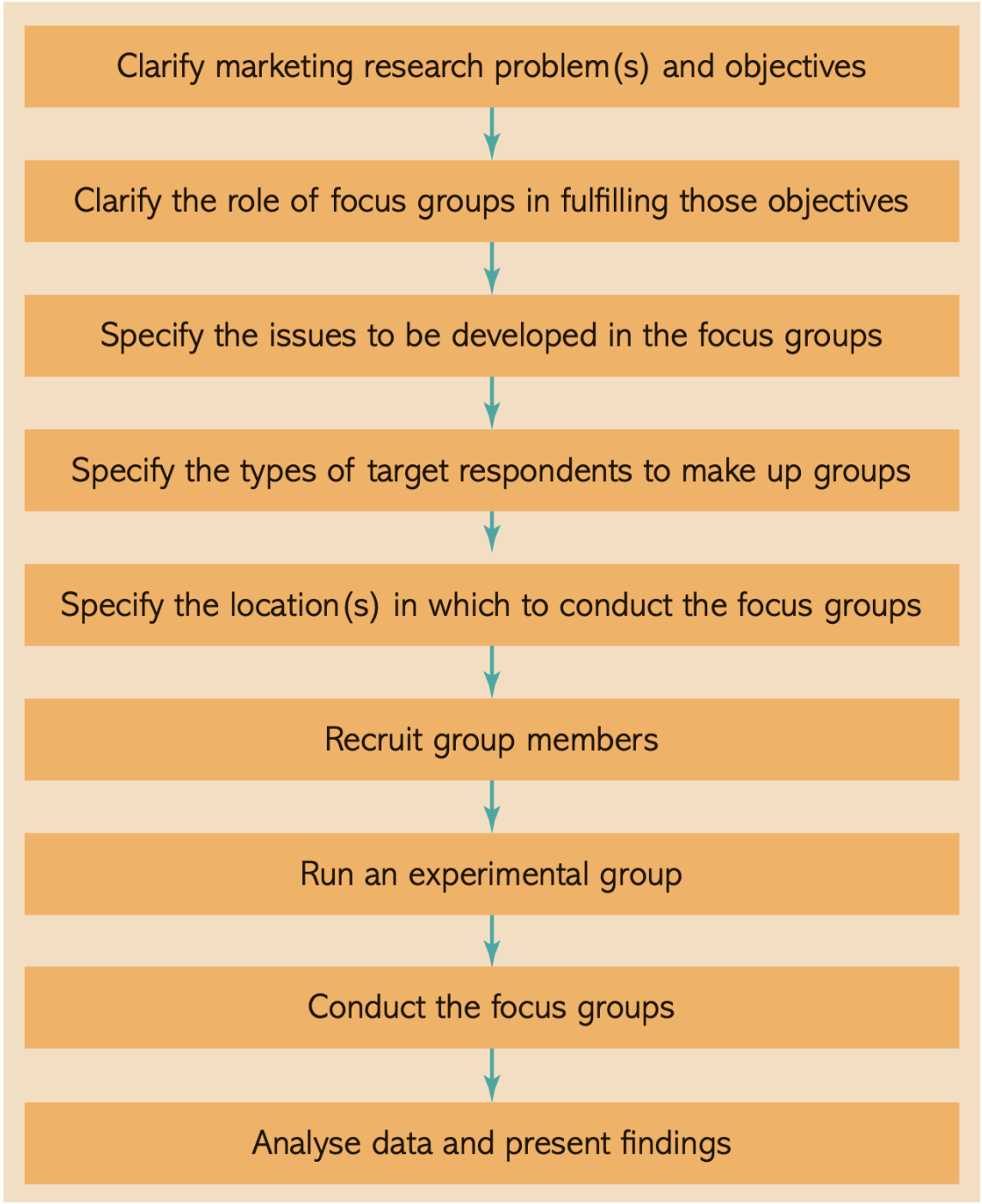
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Characteristics of the Moderator

Characteristic	Description
Kindness with Firmness	Make members feel welcome but have a firmness to stop participants from taking over
Permissiveness	Allow flow of discussion without it going off the rails
Involvement	Encourage involment of all members
Incomplete Understanding	exhibiting a feigned naïvety or incomplete understanding to get better answers
Encouragement	Must encourage unresponsive members to participate.
Flexibility	able to improvise and alter the planned outline
Sensitivity	Be able to read people
Observation	Be able to observe interaction and make notes of ideas or questions

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Planning Focus Groups



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Clarifying

- That the whole process is founded upon a clear awareness of the gaps in the knowledge of marketing decision makers.
- The objectives of using focus groups should be clarified
- There should be a clear understanding of what information can be elicited and what the limitations of the technique are.

Clarify marketing research problem

Clarify role of focus group

Specify the issues

Specify the types of target respondents

Specify the location

Recruit group members

Run an experimental group

Conduct the focus groups

Analyze data and present findings

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Topic Guide

- A topic guide is a list of topics, questions and probes that are used by a moderator to help manage a focus group discussion.
- May be a list of specific questions but must likely is a list of broad issues
- Have a good initial question and let it flow

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Specifying Target Respondents

- The types of group members to take part in the discussions are then specified
- A questionnaire to screen potential participants is prepared
- Questionnaire includes product familiarity and knowledge,usage behaviour, attitudes towards an d participation in focus groups and standard demographic characteristics

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Choosing Location

- With the types of participants specified, consideration must be taken of what would make them relaxed and comfortable, balanced in both a physical and psychological sense.

- Should the location be physical or local
- Should the location have an observation window
- What city is best to have more people?

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Recruiting

- People are skeptical and may not be willing
- Logistics is hard
- Can be done face-to-face or through phone or email
- Must be rewarded

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How to Entice Ferrari Owners

- Creating a reward good enough to entice high-net worth individuals to participate is difficult

- They can be opinionated, demanding, often resistant to research and almost impossible to reach

- If you are Ferrari, how would you get owners to participate knowing that monetary rewards are not enticing?

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Experimental Group

- An Experimental group is an initial focus group, run to test the setting of the interview, the opening question, the topic guide and the mix of participants that make up the group.

- It is a practice run to make sure that everything works as expected.

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Clarify role of focus group

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Conducting Focus Groups

- Many focus groups can be run
- Separate people by characteristics
- Do older people respect your opinion?
- Multiple focus groups must be conducted if target groups are physically widespread

Clarify marketing research problem

Clarify role of focus group

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Number of Focus Groups

- The extent to which comparisons between different types of participants are sought.
- The types of participant to be targeted and how well they interact in a discussion
- The geographic spread of participants.
- The paradigm that underpins the planning, administration and analysis of the focus group.
- The time and budget available.

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Clarify role of focus group

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Analyzing Data

- Discussed in depth later

Two main points:

- Evolving Analysis- new info, new analysis
- Not just the narrative- Transcripts of focus groups are an important part for decision makers

Clarify marketing research problem

Clarify role of focus group

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How to get better answers

- Create interactive activities

- Have the moderator interact to get better answers

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Mood Board

- A Mood Board is a collage created in a focus group setting. Focus group participants are asked to snip words and pictures from magazines that they see as representing the values a particular brand is perceived to have. In some circumstances, collages can also be made up from audio and videotapes.



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Mood Board

Reference Point

- The moderator can use the mood board to reflect upon the discussion, in which case issues can emerge that were not so apparent in the heat of a discussion.

Enabling Device

- It can get participants to loosen up and talk more freely.
- It can help to express feelings they may not be able to put into words, or enable those words to have more clarity.

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Probing

Probing is a motivational technique used when asking questions to induce the participants to enlarge on, clarify or explain their answers.

- Would you explain further?
- Can you give me an example of what you mean?
- How does that work?

Whole Group Probing

- What about the rest of you?
- I see people nodding their heads; tell me about it.

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Brainstorming: group creativity has its own problems

Production blocking

A participant has an idea while someone else is speaking.

By the time they can speak, the idea may be forgotten or judged as redundant.

Large groups or dominant individuals can suppress quieter participants.

Evaluation apprehension

Participants worry about how others will judge their ideas.

They censor unusual or risky ideas.

The group becomes less creative precisely when creativity is needed.

Online vs. Traditional Focus Groups

Dimension	Online	Traditional
Typical size	4–8	6–10
Geography	Can be global	Usually location-bound
Duration	≈1–1.5 hr; can extend over days/weeks	≈1.5–6 hr
Setting control	Lower	Higher
Identity verification	Can be harder	Usually easier
Non-verbal cues	Limited	Rich
Physical stimuli	Limited	Broad
Transcript	Immediate	More time-consuming
Travel cost	None/minimal	Potentially substantial

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Online groups: strengths and weaknesses

Strengths

- Geographic reach
- Convenience for busy participants
- Lower travel/facility costs
- Rapid transcription and turnaround
- Participants can upload images, links, or other materials
- Potentially greater candor when identities are less visible

Weaknesses

- Less non-verbal information
- Harder to verify identity and attentiveness
- Less control over the participant's environment
- Limited ability to test physical/sensory products
- Technology and access can create selection problems
- Some group dynamics are weaker online

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Other Focus Groups

- **Two-way groups**: one target group observes or reacts to another.
- **Dual-moderator groups**: one moderator manages flow; another ensures key topics are covered.
- **Duelling-moderator groups**: moderators deliberately take opposing positions to stimulate debate.
- **Participant–moderator groups**: participants temporarily assume moderation roles.
- Client–participant groups: client personnel join to clarify issues.
- **Mini-groups**: approximately four or five participants when deeper probing is needed.
- **Telephone groups**: useful for geographically dispersed experts.

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Five misconceptions about focus groups

- Economical — they are not automatically cheap or quick once recruitment, moderation, analysis, and facilities are considered.
- Experts — professional moderators help, but contextual fit, cultural sensitivity, and participant rapport can matter more than experience alone.
- Easily upset — sensitive topics can be researched, but require careful design, ethics, and moderation.
- Endorsement — focus groups do not always need to be 'validated' by quantitative research; their purpose can be understanding.
- Exposure — stated attitudes are not the same as observed behavior; qualitative data should not be treated as behavioral prediction by default.

What is an in-depth interview?

An unstructured, direct, personal interview in which one participant is probed by an experienced interviewer.

The goal is to uncover underlying motivations, beliefs, attitudes, feelings, meanings, and experiences.

The participant is treated as a friend

The emphasis is on interpretation and meaning—not merely collecting factual statements.

Compared with a focus group, there is no group pressure to conform to a perceived consensus.

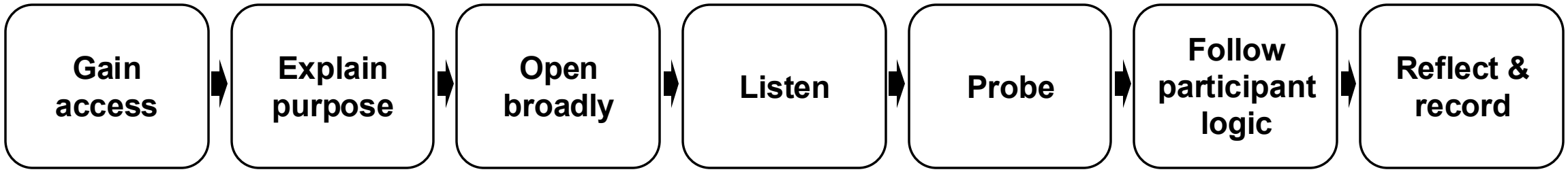
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Meaning of "Deep"

- Everyday events: understand experiences that participants normally do not explain.
- Context: move beyond common-sense descriptions to the boundaries and meanings surrounding an experience.
- Multi-faceted: recognize that different participants can attach different meanings to the same object or event.
- Interviewer reflection: examine how the researcher's assumptions, identity, and experience shape what is heard.

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The in-depth interview process



A topic guide acts as a memory aid rather than a rigid script.

The participant's responses determine the next question and the depth of probing.

The interviewer should avoid accepting unexplained 'yes'/'no' answers when deeper understanding is needed.

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What makes a strong in-depth interviewer?

Develop empathy and rapport.

Create a comfortable context.

Be personable without becoming the subject of the interview.

Listen for issues that energize the participant.

Probe without leading.

Understand the participant's language, technical terms, and context.

Notice what is not fully explained.

Reflect on how the interviewer may be shaping the interaction.

Why choose an in-depth interview?

Especially useful when

The issue is sensitive or confidential.

Social norms create pressure to conform.

The participant is an expert, manager, or elite respondent.

The research requires very detailed probing.

The behavior is habitual, tacit, complicated, or highly contextual.

Additional advantages

Responses can be attributed directly to one participant.

No group pressure to agree.

Easier to arrange around one participant's schedule.

The interview can occur in the participant's natural context.

Individual interviews allow experimentation with the method.

Challenges of in-depth interviewing

Interviewer influence can be substantial because the interaction is less structured.

A small number of interviews may be possible because interviews can be time-intensive and expensive.

Rich data are not automatically easy data: interpretation can be difficult.

Participants may communicate through indirect language, omissions, metaphors, or contradictions.

The researcher needs theoretical sensitivity or a disciplined approach to developing interpretations.

Participant selection still matters: articulate participants are not necessarily representative participants.

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Unilever's Research

Unilever’s Axe men’s range of toiletries was inspired by an unconventional approach to consumer research.

- The research approach started with in-depth interviews with a group of individuals identified as experts in ‘understanding men’ and what drives them.
- The experts included a professor of evolutionary psychology, sex psychologists, adult film directors, a ‘burlesque’ dancer, a game developer and a senior writer on Loaded magazine.
- They were all interviewed in their own working environments, either by Unilever’s Consumer Insight Manager or using researchers from the international qualitative and youth research company Firefish

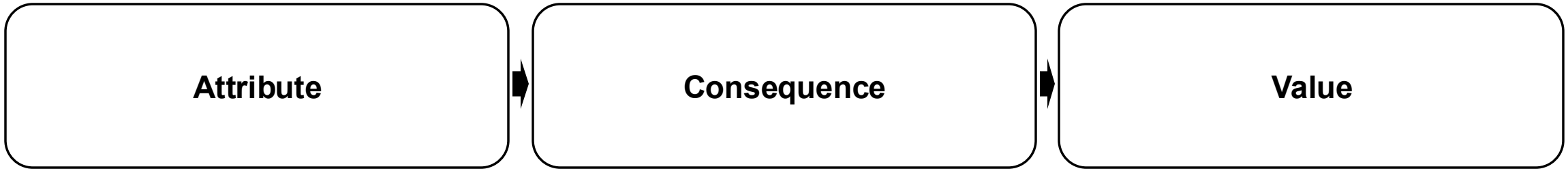
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In depth Interview Techniques

- Laddering
- Repratory Grid Technique
- The Zaltman metaphor elicitation technique

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Laddering: moving from attributes to values



Example: Low calories → less fattening → health

Laddering uses probing to uncover the chain connecting product characteristics to personal meanings.

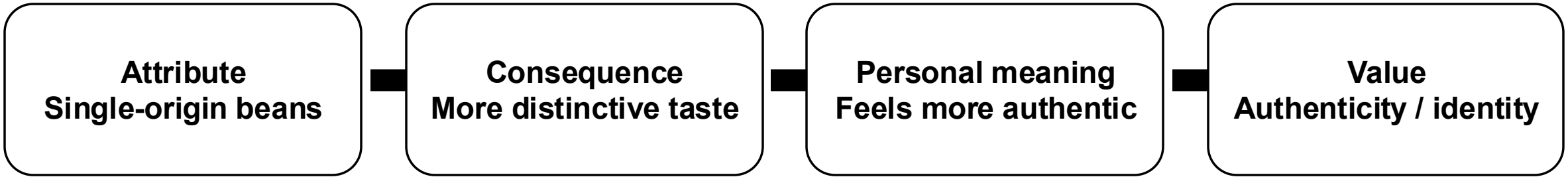
It is grounded in a means–end perspective: tangible attributes can produce consequences that connect to deeper values.

The interviewer repeatedly asks questions such as: “What does that difference mean?” and “Why is that important to you?”

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Laddering in practice

Suppose a customer prefers one type of coffee over another:



The point is not the exact chain. The point is to uncover how the participant connects product features to personally meaningful outcomes.

Repertory grid technique

Originally associated with George Kelly's personal construct psychology.

Designed to uncover constructs that participants use to make sense of objects, brands, products, or experiences.

Participants first select relevant elements.

The interviewer presents triads: two elements are alike in some way, while the third differs.

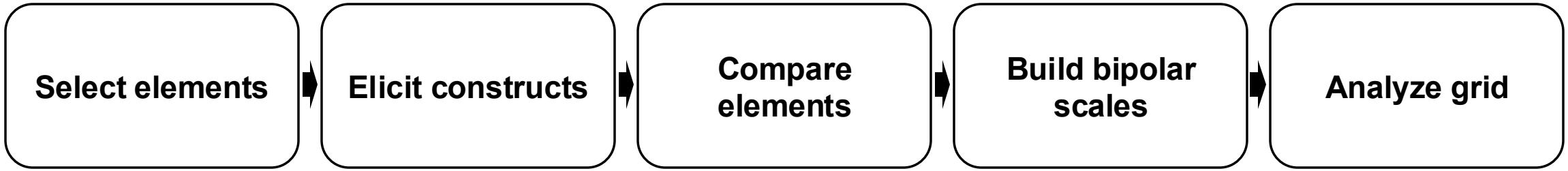
The participant's comparison generates a personal construct.

Constructs can be converted into bipolar scales and used to rate the elements.

The resulting grid can be analyzed to identify patterns and dimensions.

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Repertory grid: the logic



Example construct: “many competing products” ↔ “few comparable products”

Once multiple grids are available, factor analysis or cluster analysis can help identify broader patterns.

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Zaltman Metaphor Elicitation Technique (ZMET)

Participants gather images that represent thoughts or feelings about a brand, issue, or advertisement.

The images become prompts for an in-depth interview.

The participant explains what each image means and how it connects to the research topic.

Probing explores causes, consequences, emotions, and relationships among ideas.

The objective is to reveal both spoken and more tacit/emotional associations.

The output can be represented as a 'mental map' or consensus map of the market.

Images can sometimes communicate emotional meaning more effectively than literal questions.

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Projective Techniques

- Projective techniques are an unstructured and indirect form of questioning which encourages participants to project their underlying motivations, beliefs, attitudes or feelings regarding the issues of concern
- These are mostly used in in-depth interviews

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Projective Techniques

Types of projective technique include:

- Association technique
- Completion Technique
- Construction Technique
- Expressive Technique

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Association technique is a type of projective technique in which participants are presented with a stimulus and are asked to respond with the first thing that comes to mind.

Word association is a projective technique in which participants are presented with a list of words, one at a time. After each word, they are asked to give the first word that comes to mind.

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Word Association Example

Word association was used to study womens' attitudes towards detergents. Below is a list of stimulus words used and the responses of two women of similar age and household status. The sets of responses are quite different, suggesting that the women differ in personality and in their attitudes towards housekeeping. Ms M's associations suggest that she is resigned to dirt. She sees dirt as inevitable and does not do much about it. She does not do hard cleaning, nor does she get much pleasure from her family. Ms C sees dirt too, but is energetic, factual-minded and less emotional. She is actively ready to combat dirt, and she uses soap and water as her weapons.

Stimulus	Ms M	Ms C
Washday	Everyday	Ironing
Fresh	And sweet	Clean
Pure	Air	Soiled
Scrub	Does not; husband does	Clean
Filth	This neighbourhood	Dirt
Bubbles	Bath	Soap and water
Family	Squabbles	Children
Towels	Dirty	Wash

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Completion Techniques

A projective technique that requires participants to complete an incomplete stimulus situation.

Sentence completion- A projective technique in which participants are presented with a number of incomplete sentences and are asked to complete them.

Story completion- A projective technique in which participants are provided with part of a story and are required to give the conclusion in their own words.

Sentence completion

A Formula One fan that supports a team rather than a driver is _____

_____

A sponsor who selects drivers based on how competitive they are is _____

_____

The Ferrari team is most preferred by _____

_____

When I think of watching Formula One on television, I _____

Construction Techniques

- Construction technique is a projective technique in which participants are required to construct a response in the form of a story, dialogue or description.
- **Picture Response Technique**- a projective technique in which participants are shown a picture and are asked to tell a story describing it.
- **Cartoon Tests-** Cartoon characters are shown in a specific situation related to the problem. Participants are asked to indicate the dialogue that one cartoon character might make in response to the comment(s) of another character.

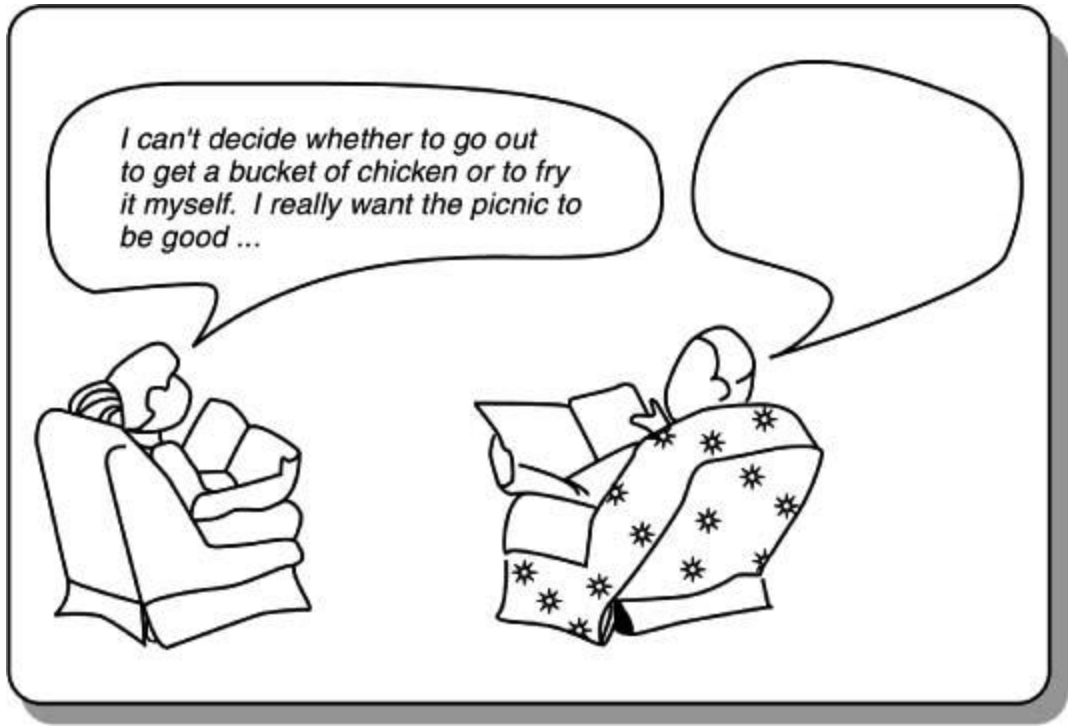
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Picture Response Technique



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Cartoon Test



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Expressive Techniques

- Expressive technique is a projective technique in which participants are presented with a verbal or visual situation and are asked to relate the feelings and attitudes of other people to the situation.
- Role playing- Participants are asked to assume the behaviour of someone else or a specific object.
- Third-person technique- A projective technique in which participants are presented with a verbal or visual situation and are asked to relate the beliefs and attitudes of a third person in that situation.

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Expressive Techniques

- **Role playing-** Participants are asked to assume the behavior of someone else or a specific object.
- **Third-person technique-** A projective technique in which participants are presented with a verbal or visual situation and are asked to relate the beliefs and attitudes of a third person in that situation.
- **Personification Technique-** Participants are asked to imagine that the brand is a person and then describe characteristics of that person.

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Third Person Techniques

- How do your neighbors react when there are construction noises?

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Beer Brand Example

If the following beer brands were people, how would they interact with each other at a barbecue:

- Patricia
- Pilsen
- Norteña
- Patagonia
- Stella Artois

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Comparison of Qualitative Techniques

Criteria	Focus groups	In-depth interviews	Projective techniques	Ethnographic techniques
Degree of structure	Can vary from highly to loosely structured	Can vary from highly to loosely structured	Tends to be loosely structured	Loosely structured though can have a framework to guide observation
Probing of individual participants	Low	High	Medium	None when used in isolation and in a covert manner
Moderator bias	Medium	Relatively high	Low to high	None when used in isolation and in a covert manner
Uncovering subconscious information	Low	Medium to high	High	High
Discovering innovative information	High	Medium	Low	Medium
Obtaining sensitive information	Low	Medium	High	High
Involving unusual behaviour or questioning	No	To a limited extent	Yes	Perhaps on the part of the observer